Thesis Structure and Writing

How to Write Each Chapter

A Thesis Guide

Darkhan Mentor

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Abstract

A thesis is the longest piece of academic writing most students will ever produce, and its difficulty lies less in the research itself than in turning months or years of work into one clear, sustained argument. This guide treats the thesis as exactly that: a single argument developed chapter by chapter, from the research question to the final recommendation. Each chapter has a distinct job to do, and this guide explains what that job is, how long the chapter should normally be, what examiners look for in it, and which mistakes most often weaken it.

The guide follows the standard structure used in most universities: an introduction that states the problem and the question; a literature review that maps what is already known and identifies the gap; a methodology chapter that justifies every choice of design, data and analysis; a results chapter that presents findings clearly through tables, figures and text; a discussion that interprets those findings against the literature; and a conclusion that answers the question and states the contribution. Around this core, it covers the abstract, acknowledgements and appendices, academic writing style, formatting and referencing, preparation for the defence (viva), and the most common mistakes students make.

Throughout, the emphasis is practical. Each chapter includes worked examples of good and weak writing, sample tables, and checklists a student can use before submitting a draft to a supervisor. The advice applies to master's and doctoral theses in the social sciences, humanities, education, business and the applied sciences, and it can be adapted to the specific regulations of any university. The aim is simple: that a student who follows this guide should be able to plan the whole document before writing a word, draft each chapter with confidence, and defend the finished thesis with a clear understanding of what it claims and why that claim is justified.

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 and 2 before you write anything, to plan the whole thesis. Then work through Chapters 3 to 8 in order as you draft each chapter. Use Chapters 10 and 11 while you revise, Chapter 12 before your defence, and Chapter 13 as a final check before submission.

Chapter 1: Introduction — the Thesis as One Long Argument

Many students begin a thesis by writing the literature review, because it feels like the safest place to start. They read, they summarise, and after three months they have forty pages of summaries and no thesis. The problem is not laziness. It is that they have started with the wrong question. The first question of a thesis is not 'What has been written about my topic?' It is 'What am I trying to prove, and what would count as evidence for it?'

A thesis is one long argument. Every chapter is a move in that argument. The introduction states the claim and the question. The literature review shows why the question is still open. The methodology shows how the evidence was gathered fairly. The results present the evidence. The discussion argues what the evidence means. The conclusion states what has been established and what follows from it. If a paragraph does not serve that argument, it does not belong in the thesis, however interesting it is.

1.1 The difference between a thesis and an essay

An essay answers a question set by someone else, in a few thousand words, and is judged mainly on understanding. A thesis asks its own question, answers it with original evidence, and is judged on whether the answer is new, sound and defensible. An essay can survey a topic. A thesis must make a contribution: a new finding, a new explanation, a new method, or a new application of an existing idea to a new context. Even at master's level, examiners look for a clear statement of what is new, however modest.

Length follows from this difference. A thesis is long because the argument is long: the evidence must be described, the alternatives considered, and the objections answered. But length is not the goal. A tight thesis of 15,000 words that answers its question is stronger than a loose one of 30,000 words that wanders. Examiners reward focus, not volume.

1.2 Start with the question, not the topic

A topic is a field: 'student motivation', 'water quality', 'small business finance'. A research question is a sentence that can be answered: 'Does weekly formative feedback improve the test scores of Grade 9 mathematics students in public schools?' The question does three things at once. It defines what data you need, it tells you which literature matters, and it tells the reader when the thesis has succeeded — when the question has been answered. Write your question on a card and keep it above your desk. Every chapter you draft should be tested against it.

Worked Example: From topic to question

Topic: 'English language teaching.' Too broad — it could fill a library. Narrowed question: 'Does peer feedback improve the writing accuracy of intermediate English learners in a six-week course?' This version names the intervention (peer feedback), the outcome (writing accuracy), the population (intermediate learners) and the time frame (six weeks). A reader now knows exactly what the thesis will test.

1.3 Plan the whole document before drafting

Before writing Chapter 1, sketch the whole thesis in one page: the question, the claim you expect to defend, one sentence per chapter saying what that chapter will do, and the evidence each chapter will use. Show this plan to your supervisor early. It is far cheaper to change a plan than to rewrite forty pages. Most supervisors would rather discuss a one-page plan than read a long draft that has gone in the wrong direction.

[ ] My research question is written as one clear sentence.

[ ] I can state in one sentence what is new about my study.

[ ] I have a one-page plan with one sentence per chapter.

[ ] My supervisor has seen and discussed the plan.

Chapter 2: The Standard Thesis Structure at a Glance

Universities differ in detail, but the standard structure below is recognised almost everywhere. Always check your own university's regulations first: they may require a specific order, a declaration page, or a fixed word count. Where the regulations and this guide disagree, the regulations win. The table gives typical lengths for a master's thesis of about 15,000–20,000 words; a doctoral thesis is usually two to four times longer, with the same proportions roughly preserved.

Chapter	Purpose	Typical length
Abstract	Summary of the whole thesis: question, method, findings, conclusion	250-350 words
1. Introduction	Problem, question, aims, significance, outline of the thesis	8-12%
2. Literature Review	What is known, what is contested, where the gap is	20-25%
3. Methodology	Design, participants, instruments, procedure, analysis, ethics	12-15%
4. Results / Findings	What the data show, in text, tables and figures	15-20%
5. Discussion	What the results mean, compared with the literature	12-15%
6. Conclusion	Answer to the question, contribution, limitations, recommendations	5-8%
References	Every source cited, in the required style	As needed
Appendices	Instruments, raw data, permissions, extra tables	As needed

Two things in the table deserve attention. First, the literature review is usually the

longest chapter, but it is not a dumping ground for everything you have read. It is a selective argument that ends in a gap your study fills. Second, the results and discussion are often combined in qualitative theses, where findings and interpretation develop together. That is acceptable if your department allows it — but keep the two functions distinct in your mind even when they share a chapter, so that evidence and interpretation never blur into each other.

Chapter 3: Writing the Introduction Chapter

The introduction chapter has four jobs: to show that the problem matters, to state the research question, to explain how the study will answer it, and to give the reader a map of the thesis. It is not a mini literature review and not a summary of the results. Think of it as a contract with the reader: by the end of this chapter, the reader should know what you will do, why it is worth doing, and how the rest of the document is organised.

3.1 The funnel: from the general problem to your question

A strong introduction opens wide and narrows steadily. Begin with the broad problem in one or two paragraphs — for example, that many secondary school students leave school with weak mathematics skills. Then narrow to the specific aspect your study addresses: the role of formative feedback in one grade, in one subject, in one setting. Then state the gap: although feedback is widely recommended, little is known about its effect in this particular context. Then state your question and aims. This funnel structure is the most reliable way to open a thesis, and examiners expect to see it.

3.2 Aims, objectives and research questions

Keep the hierarchy clear. The aim is the broad purpose: 'to investigate the effect of peer feedback on writing accuracy'. The objectives are the concrete steps: to measure accuracy before and after the intervention; to compare the peer-feedback group with a control group; to explore students' perceptions of the process. The research questions are the sentences the thesis will answer. One main question and two or three sub-questions are enough. More than that, and the study loses focus.

Worked Example: Weak and strong aim statements

Weak: 'This study aims to look at English teaching.' It names no outcome, no population and no method. Strong: 'This study aims to determine whether structured peer feedback improves the grammatical accuracy of intermediate English learners over six weeks, compared with teacher feedback alone.' The strong version can be tested, measured and answered — and the reader can tell at once whether the thesis has succeeded.

3.3 Significance and scope

Significance answers the question 'So what?' Explain who benefits if your findings hold: teachers who need practical strategies, policymakers who allocate training budgets, or researchers who need evidence in an untested context. Be honest and specific; do not claim your small study will transform national education. Scope states

the boundaries: the place, the population, the time period and the variables you did not study. Stating limits early is a strength, not a weakness — it shows you understand what your evidence can and cannot support.

Chapter 4: Writing the Literature Review Chapter

The literature review is the chapter students most often get wrong, because they treat it as a summary of everything they have read. It is not. It is an argument built from the literature, and its conclusion is the gap your study fills. A good review organises sources by theme, compares them, evaluates them, and ends with a clear statement of what remains unknown. A weak review lists authors one after another — 'Smith (2019) found... Jones (2020) found...' — without ever saying what the pattern is.

4.1 Organise by theme, not by author

Group the literature into three to five themes that follow from your question. In a study of peer feedback, the themes might be: theories of feedback; feedback and writing accuracy; peer feedback versus teacher feedback; and feedback in the local context. Within each theme, discuss several studies together: where they agree, where they disagree, and why. The disagreement is often the most valuable part, because it shows the reader that the field has not settled the question — which is exactly why your study is needed.

4.2 Summarise, synthesise, evaluate

Three levels of work appear in every paragraph of a good review. Summarise: what did the study do and find? Synthesise: how does it fit with the other studies in this theme? Evaluate: how strong is the evidence — was the sample large, the method sound, the context similar to yours? Most student reviews stop at summary. The marks are earned at the second and third levels. A single sentence of evaluation — 'However, the study used only twelve students and no control group, so its findings are suggestive rather than conclusive' — is worth more than a page of uncritical summary.

Worked Example: From listing to synthesis

Listing: 'Ali (2021) studied feedback in Lahore. Khan (2022) studied feedback in Karachi. Raza (2023) studied feedback in Islamabad.' Synthesis: 'Studies in three Pakistani cities agree that students value feedback but rarely act on it (Ali, 2021; Khan, 2022; Raza, 2023). However, all three relied on self-report questionnaires, and none measured whether accuracy actually improved — the gap this study addresses.' The second version turns three facts into one argument.

4.4 Ending the review: the gap and the conceptual framework

The final section of the review is the most important. State the gap explicitly: what is missing, contested or untested. Then state how your study addresses it, and present your conceptual framework — the diagram or set of relationships that guides your

study. If your study tests whether feedback improves accuracy, the framework shows the variables and the expected relationship between them. This section is the bridge from the review to the methodology chapter, and the examiner will judge your whole thesis partly on whether the bridge holds.

[ ] Sources are grouped by theme, not listed author by author.

[ ] Each theme ends with a synthesis of what the studies show together.

[ ] Key studies are evaluated for method and sample, not just summarised.

[ ] The gap is stated explicitly in the final section.

[ ] Every claim is referenced; no uncited generalisation remains.

Chapter 5: Writing the Methodology Chapter

The methodology chapter must allow a competent reader to understand exactly what you did, why you did it, and whether they could repeat it. It is the chapter examiners scrutinise most closely for rigour, because a weak method undermines everything that follows. Write it in the past tense, in enough detail that replication is possible, and justify every major choice: why this design, why this sample, why this instrument, why this analysis. A choice without a reason looks arbitrary; a choice with a reason looks like a decision.

5.1 Research design

Name the design and explain why it fits the question. An experiment tests cause and effect; a survey describes attitudes or practices across a population; a case study explores a phenomenon in depth in its real context; a mixed-methods design combines numbers and words to answer different parts of the question. State the design in one sentence, then defend it in a paragraph: what alternatives did you consider, and why was this one the best fit for your question, your time and your access?

5.2 Participants, sampling and setting

Describe who took part, how many, how they were selected, and where the study happened. Give the numbers: the population, the sample size, the response rate, and the characteristics that matter (age, grade, experience). Explain the sampling method — random, purposive, convenience — and be honest about its limits. A convenience sample is not a disgrace, but it must be named as one, and its effect on generalisation must be discussed in the conclusion.

5.3 Instruments and data collection

Describe each instrument: the questionnaire, the test, the interview schedule, the observation checklist. Say where it came from — adapted from an earlier study, or designed by you — and report its quality: pilot testing, reliability coefficients, expert review of content validity. Describe the procedure step by step, in the order it happened, with dates and durations. Put the full instruments in an appendix and refer the reader to them.

5.4 Data analysis

Name the analysis before you present the results. For quantitative data, state the statistical tests and the software, and the significance level you used. For qualitative data, state the approach — thematic analysis, for example — and the steps you followed: transcription, coding, searching for themes, checking them against the data. Explain how you handled missing data and how you checked the trustworthiness of your analysis, for example by having a second coder check a sample of transcripts.

5.5 Ethics

Every thesis involving people must address ethics: informed consent, voluntary participation, the right to withdraw, confidentiality, and secure storage of data. State the approval you obtained — from your university's ethics committee, the school, or the relevant authority — and give the reference number if one was issued. Describe in practical terms what participants were told and how their identities were protected. Examiners treat a missing ethics section as a serious fault, not a formality.

Worked Example: Justifying a choice, not just naming it

Weak: 'A questionnaire was used.' The reader learns nothing about why. Strong: 'A questionnaire was used because the study needed comparable data from 120 students in four schools within three weeks, which interviews could not provide in the time available. The items were adapted from a validated instrument, piloted with 15 students, and revised after the pilot showed that two items were misunderstood.' The strong version gives the reason, the constraint, and the quality check — the three things an examiner looks for.

- [ ] Design, sample, instruments, procedure and analysis are all described.
- [ ] Every major choice is justified, with alternatives considered.
- [ ] Instruments are piloted or validated; reliability is reported.
- [ ] Ethical approval and consent procedures are stated.
- [ ] A reader could repeat the study from this chapter alone.

Chapter 6: Presenting Results: Tables, Figures and Text

The results chapter presents what you found — nothing more. Do not interpret the findings here, do not compare them with the literature, and do not explain why they happened. That is the discussion chapter's job. The results chapter's job is to give the reader a clear, accurate picture of the data, so that when the discussion begins, the reader already trusts the evidence. The most common fault in this chapter is mixing results with interpretation, so that the reader cannot tell where the data end and the author's opinion begins.

6.1 Organise by research question

Structure the chapter around your research questions or objectives, in the same order they appeared in the introduction. Give each question its own section, with its

own heading. Within each section, present the findings in a logical order — usually from the most general to the most specific, or in the order the data were collected. Begin each section with one sentence saying what the reader will find, then present the evidence.

6.2 Tables and figures

Use tables for precise numbers and figures for patterns. A table lets the reader find an exact value; a chart lets the reader see a trend at a glance. Never present the same data in both a table and a figure — choose the form that serves the reader best. Every table and figure needs a number, a clear title, and a note explaining it. In the text, refer to each one by number ('Table 4.2 shows...') and point out the one or two findings that matter most. Do not repeat every number in the text; the table already contains them.

Group	Pre-test mean	Post-test mean	Gain
Peer feedback (n = 60)	58.4	71.2	+12.8
Teacher feedback (n = 60)	57.9	66.3	+8.4
Control (n = 60)	58.1	59.6	+1.5

Table 6.1 (above) is an example of a results table. Note what it does: the title would normally sit above the table in the thesis; the groups are named; the sample sizes are shown; and the key column — the gain — is visible at a glance. In the text, the writer would draw attention to the comparison that matters: the peer-feedback group gained 12.8 points, against 8.4 for teacher feedback and 1.5 for the control group. The table carries the numbers; the text carries the message.

6.4 Qualitative findings

In a qualitative thesis, the results chapter presents themes, each illustrated with short quotations from participants. Choose quotations that show the theme clearly, not the longest ones. Introduce each quotation, give it a participant code rather than a name, and keep quotations short — one or two sentences each. The theme, not the quotation, is the finding; the quotation is the evidence for it. Aim for three to five themes, not fifteen, so that each one can be developed properly.

- [ ] Results are organised by research question, in the same order as the introduction.
- [ ] Every table and figure is numbered, titled and referred to in the text.
- [ ] No data appear in both a table and a figure.
- [ ] Interpretation and literature comparison are saved for the discussion.
- [ ] Unexpected and non-significant results are reported, not hidden.

Chapter 7: Writing the Discussion Chapter

The discussion is where the thesis earns its marks. Results describe what happened; the discussion argues what it means. A strong discussion does four things: it answers each research question directly, it compares the findings with the earlier literature, it explains unexpected results, and it acknowledges the study's limitations honestly. Students often write the discussion as a second results chapter, repeating the numbers. Resist that. The reader has already seen the numbers; now they need your judgement.

7.1 Answer the questions first

Begin the discussion by answering each research question in turn, in one paragraph per question, referring back to the key evidence. Do not make the reader wait until the end of the chapter to learn the answer. A useful opening sentence is: 'The first research question asked whether peer feedback improves writing accuracy. The evidence suggests that it does, and by a larger margin than teacher feedback.' Everything after that sentence supports, qualifies or explains it.

7.2 Compare with the literature

For each main finding, return to the literature review and say whether your results agree or disagree with earlier studies, and why. Agreement strengthens the earlier finding and extends it to a new context. Disagreement is often more interesting: it may be explained by a different population, a different instrument, a different time period, or a genuine change in the phenomenon. Do not ignore studies that contradict you. Examiners will have read them, and a thesis that confronts contrary evidence is far stronger than one that pretends it does not exist.

7.4 Limitations — stated, not apologised for

State the limitations plainly: the sample was small, the study ran for six weeks, the test measured only one kind of accuracy. Then say what each limitation means for the findings: which conclusions it weakens and which it leaves untouched. A limitation is not an apology. Every study has limits, and naming them shows that you understand the reach of your own evidence. What damages a thesis is not having limitations, but pretending not to have them.

Worked Example: A discussion paragraph that does the work

'The peer-feedback group improved by 12.8 points, compared with 8.4 for teacher feedback. This supports the claim that structured peer interaction helps learners notice errors (Ali, 2021), and it extends that claim to intermediate learners in a Pakistani public-school setting, where it had not previously been tested. The most likely reason is that peer discussion forced learners to explain errors in their own words, which deepened their understanding — a mechanism also reported by Khan (2022), though in a university sample.' In five sentences this paragraph answers the question, compares with two studies, claims the contribution, and offers a mechanism. That is the standard to aim for.

[ ] Each research question is answered directly, early in the chapter.

[ ] Every main finding is compared with the earlier literature.

[ ] Unexpected results are explained, not ignored.

[ ] Limitations are stated with their consequences for the findings.

[ ] No new results appear in this chapter.

Chapter 8: Writing the Conclusion and Recommendations

The conclusion is short, and it must be. By this point the argument has been made; the conclusion states what has been established and what follows from it. Students often write a conclusion that is either a long summary that repeats the whole thesis, or a set of grand claims the evidence cannot support. Both are mistakes. Aim for a chapter the examiner can read in ten minutes and remember afterwards.

8.1 Restate the question and the answer

Open by restating the research question and giving the answer in two or three sentences. This is the thesis in miniature, and it should be the clearest passage in the whole document. Then summarise the contribution: what is now known that was not known before, and for whom it matters. Keep the summary to the main findings only; the detail belongs in the earlier chapters.

8.2 Recommendations

Recommendations follow from the findings, and each one should be traceable to a specific result. Distinguish recommendations for practice (what teachers, managers or policymakers should do), for policy (what rules or funding should change), and for further research (what the next study should investigate). Make them concrete: 'Schools should provide two hours of peer-feedback training per term' is a recommendation; 'Feedback should be improved' is a wish. Also say who should act, and on what timescale, where that is reasonable.

Chapter 9: The Abstract, Acknowledgements and Appendices

These short sections are written last, but they frame the whole thesis. The abstract is the most-read part of any thesis: examiners, librarians and future researchers may read nothing else. The acknowledgements are the most personal part. The appendices hold the evidence that would interrupt the main text. Each deserves care, even though none of them is long.

9.1 The abstract

Write the abstract after the rest of the thesis is finished, in about 250–350 words. It has four parts, in order: the problem and the question; the method (design, sample, instruments); the main findings (with the key numbers); and the conclusion and its significance. Use the past tense, avoid citations and abbreviations, and do not include

material that is not in the thesis. A reader who reads only the abstract should know what you did, what you found, and why it matters.

9.3 Appendices

Put in the appendices anything the reader may need to check but does not need to read to follow the argument: the questionnaire, the interview schedule, the test, the consent form, the ethics approval letter, large tables of raw data, and the coding framework. Number the appendices (Appendix A, Appendix B) and give each a title. Refer to each appendix at least once in the main text, so that no appendix is orphaned. Do not use the appendices to hide material that belongs in the main chapters — examiners notice, and they do not reward it.

Chapter 10: Academic Writing Style: Clarity, Precision and Voice

Academic writing is not difficult writing. The best theses are written in plain, precise English, and the examiner's highest praise is often 'this was a pleasure to read'. Clarity is not a cosmetic extra; it is how the examiner judges whether you understand your own work. If a sentence is unclear, the examiner cannot tell whether the idea behind it is sound.

10.1 Clarity: one idea per sentence

Keep sentences to twenty-five words or fewer on average. Put the main subject and verb near the start of the sentence, and keep related words together. Prefer the active voice where the actor matters: 'The researcher interviewed twelve teachers' is clearer than 'Twelve teachers were interviewed', and it tells the reader who did the work. Use the passive voice only when the actor does not matter, as in describing a standard procedure.

10.2 Precision: say exactly what you mean

Avoid vague words — 'very', 'many', 'a lot', 'things', 'aspects' — and replace them with numbers or names. Do not write 'many students improved'; write '47 of the 60 students improved by at least 10 points'. Define key terms when you first use them, and then use them consistently. If you call the intervention 'peer feedback' in Chapter 1, do not call it 'student review' in Chapter 4 and 'collaborative assessment' in Chapter 7. Inconsistent terms make the examiner wonder whether you are describing three different things.

Worked Example: Rewriting for clarity

Before: 'It is important to note that the utilisation of feedback mechanisms by learners in the educational context is a factor that has a significant impact on the improvement of their writing skills in a positive direction.' (36 words, no actor, no numbers.) After: 'Learners who used structured peer feedback improved their writing accuracy by 12.8 points over six weeks.' (16 words, clear actor, clear outcome, clear number.) The second version says more in half the space.

[ ] Average sentence length is under 25 words.

[ ] Key numbers replace vague words like 'many' and 'a lot'.

[ ] Key terms are defined once and used consistently.

[ ] Claims are hedged where the evidence is limited ('suggests', not 'proves').

[ ] The same voice is used throughout the thesis.

Chapter 11: Formatting, Referencing and Proofreading

Formatting and referencing are not decoration. They are part of the argument: consistent formatting shows the reader where they are in the document, and accurate referencing shows that every claim can be checked. Examiners treat sloppy formatting as evidence of sloppy thinking, and a single invented or mis-copied reference can damage trust in the whole thesis. Budget real time for this work — at least a week — and do not leave it to the last night.

11.1 Formatting

Follow your university's template exactly: font, font size, line spacing, margins, heading styles, page numbering and the position of tables and figures. If no template is provided, use a readable serif or sans-serif font at 11 or 12 points, 1.5 line spacing, and margins of at least 2.5 centimetres. Number chapters and sections consistently (1, 1.1, 1.2), start each chapter on a new page, and keep headings with at least two lines of text beneath them — never leave a heading alone at the bottom of a page.

11.2 Referencing

Choose the referencing style your department requires — APA, Harvard, Chicago, MLA or another — and use it without exception. Record the full details of every source as you read it, and use a reference manager to keep the list consistent. Check three things before submission: every citation in the text appears in the reference list; every entry in the reference list is cited in the text; and every reference is complete and correctly punctuated. Paraphrase more than you quote: a thesis built from long quotations looks like a collection of other people's writing.

11.3 Proofreading

Proofread in stages, not in one sitting. First, read for structure: does each chapter do its job, and does the argument flow? Second, read for sense: does each paragraph make one point, and does each sentence follow from the one before? Third, read for language: spelling, grammar, punctuation, consistency of terms and numbers. Read the thesis aloud, or have it read aloud to you — the ear catches errors the eye misses. Finally, ask a careful reader who is not in your field to read two chapters; if they cannot follow the argument, the examiner may not be able to either.

[ ] The university template and referencing style are followed throughout.

[ ] Every in-text citation has a matching reference, and vice versa.

[ ] Headings, tables and figures are numbered consistently.

[ ] The thesis has been read aloud at least once.

[ ] A reader outside the field has checked two chapters for clarity.

Chapter 12: Preparing for the Defence (Viva)

The defence — called the viva voce, or viva, in many universities — is an oral examination of the thesis, usually lasting one to three hours. Its purpose is not to catch you out. The examiners want to establish that the work is yours, that you understand it, and that you can defend its claims. Most candidates who know their thesis well pass, often with minor corrections. Preparation, not brilliance, is what makes the difference.

12.1 What examiners ask

Examiners ask the same kinds of questions in almost every defence. Why did you choose this topic? What is original about your study? Why did you choose this method rather than another? How do you explain this unexpected result? What are the limitations? What would you do differently if you started again? What should future research investigate? Prepare a two-minute answer to each of these before the day, and practise saying them aloud. If you cannot answer 'What is original about your study?' in one sentence, return to Chapter 1 and find the answer before the defence.

12.2 Preparing the presentation

Many defences begin with a short presentation of ten to twenty minutes. Structure it like the thesis in miniature: the problem, the question, the method, the main findings, the contribution. Use few slides, large text, and one clear visual per finding. Do not read the slides aloud; the examiners have the thesis. Rehearse the presentation with a timer, and rehearse it standing up, because that is how you will deliver it.

12.3 On the day

Bring a copy of the thesis, a notebook, and a list of the corrections you already know are needed — examiners respect a candidate who has found their own errors. Listen to each question in full before answering, and if you do not understand a question, ask the examiner to rephrase it. It is acceptable to say 'I need a moment to think' or 'I do not know, but the evidence suggests...'. Never invent an answer, and never argue with an examiner about a fact you are unsure of. If you disagree with a criticism, say so calmly and give your reason; examiners expect a discussion, not a surrender.

Chapter 13: Common Mistakes and a Final Checklist

The mistakes below appear in thesis after thesis, in every subject and every university. They are not mistakes of intelligence; they are mistakes of planning, and every one of them is avoidable. Read this chapter a week before submission, when there is still time to fix what it finds.

13.1 The ten most common mistakes

- No clear research question — the thesis describes a topic instead of answering a question.
- A literature review that lists authors instead of building an argument that ends in a gap.
- A methodology chapter that names choices without justifying them.
- Results mixed with interpretation, so the reader cannot tell evidence from opinion.
- A discussion that repeats the results instead of interpreting them.
- Claims bigger than the evidence — 'proves' where the data only 'suggest'.
- Inconsistent terms, numbers and formatting from chapter to chapter.
- References that are incomplete, inconsistent, or missing from the list.
- A conclusion that introduces new material instead of concluding.
- Leaving proofreading to the last night, when there is no time to fix what it finds.

13.2 The final checklist

Work through this checklist with the printed thesis in front of you. Tick each item only when you have checked it on the page, not from memory.

[ ] Title page, declaration, abstract and contents are complete and correct.

[ ] The research question is stated in the introduction and answered in the conclusion.

[ ] Every chapter has a clear purpose, stated in its opening paragraph.

[ ] The literature review ends in a stated gap that the study fills.

[ ] The methodology chapter would allow a reader to repeat the study.

[ ] Every table and figure is numbered, titled and referred to in the text.

[ ] The discussion answers each question and compares findings with the literature.

[ ] Recommendations follow from specific findings.

[ ] Every citation appears in the reference list, and every reference is cited.

[ ] Page numbers, headings and the table of contents match.

[ ] The thesis has been proofread aloud, and a second reader has checked it.

[ ] The file is saved in the required format, with a backup copy kept separately.

Chapter 14: Conclusion

A thesis is a long undertaking, and the students who finish it are rarely the most brilliant in their cohort. They are the most organised: they plan the whole document before they write it, they write a little every day, they show drafts to their supervisor early and often, and they treat feedback as information rather than criticism. The structure in this guide is a tool for that organisation. It tells you what each chapter must do, so that you never have to face a blank page wondering what to write.

If you take one idea from this guide, let it be this: the thesis is one argument, and every chapter is a move in it. State the question clearly. Show why it is still open. Gather the evidence fairly. Present it honestly. Interpret it carefully. State what has been established and what follows. Do that, in plain and precise language, and the thesis will stand up to examination — not because it is long, but because it is sound.

Write the first draft badly if you must; a bad draft can be revised, and a blank page cannot. Then revise with the checklists in this guide, proofread with fresh eyes, and defend the work with the confidence of someone who knows exactly what it claims and why. Good luck — and get writing.

Suggested Reading

The following are well-known general works on research methodology and academic writing that students commonly consult. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- General research methods textbooks: standard methodology texts used in most universities cover research design, sampling, data collection and analysis for quantitative, qualitative and mixed-methods studies.
- Academic writing guides: widely used guides to writing theses and dissertations explain structure, argument and style, with examples of good practice at master's and doctoral level.
- Style manuals: the official manuals of the major referencing styles (APA, Harvard, Chicago, MLA) are the authoritative source for citation and formatting rules — consult the edition your department requires.
- Your university's thesis regulations and template: always the first and final authority on structure, word count, formatting and submission requirements.
- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and method.